

COMP301

Software Design

Confidence Agent

Practical Three

An investigation into how thoughtful software design can improve the trustworthiness of AI systems through benchmark design, experimental methodology, validation architectures, and evidence-based evaluation.

by The Skeptics

University of
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Project Formalities

Domain

Static Verification of API Hallucinations in LLM-Generated Code.

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Agents vs Foundation Models

Hallucination Behaviour Across Four Commercial Agents and a Group Foundation-Model Baseline (Qwen)

Practical Session 03 — Group Report – *This report was Generated using AI based off our Findings, all ideas were tailored by Group Members*

1. Purpose and Concepts

This report presents the findings of Practical Session 03, which investigates hallucination behaviour across four publicly available LLM agents — Gemini, ChatGPT, Copilot, and DeepSeek — and compares those findings against our group's own foundation-model baseline, Qwen3.6-35B-A3B (referred to throughout as "Qwen").

A foundation model is a large pre-trained language model queried directly: it receives a prompt and returns a single completion with no external tools, retrieval, or orchestration layer. An LLM agent, by contrast, wraps a foundation model in additional machinery — system prompts, tool use (web search, code execution), retrieval-augmented generation, and sometimes post-generation checking — that can shape, correct, or contextualise the model's raw output before it reaches the user. The central question this practical investigates is whether, and how, that additional agentic machinery changes the rate and character of hallucination relative to a bare foundation model.

Qwen was queried directly with no tools, no search, and no system-level verification layer — it represents the foundation-model condition against which the four agents are compared.

2. Methodology

Ten one-shot coding prompts were constructed, each embedding a credible hallucination trap. Three items (P2, P4, P10) are the original MBPP-derived traps: an ambiguous phrasing with a non-obvious ground truth, an undefined/misspelled technical term resembling a real one (“woodball” vs. Woodall number), and a request to cite a specific external MBPP test case (fabricated-citation bait). The remaining seven items (P1, P3, P5–P9) — the original trap-free MBPP tasks, which failed the “at least one hallucination” validation rule — were replaced with API/library hallucination-trap prompts drawn from DataSet_DeepSeek_1_-_320.json, spanning invented methods (a nonexistent AWS S3 removeObject()), fabricated endpoints (GitHub /users/{user}/repositories), deprecated/removed APIs (ssl.wrap_socket), insecure defaults (Spring Security permitAll), platform limitations (POSIX permissions on Windows), unsupported constructs (SQLite stored procedures), and annotation confusion (@Controller vs. @RestController), across Java and Python. Each prompt was submitted once to Qwen and once to each of the four agents, using a new/temporary chat per prompt to minimise cross-contamination. No prompt explicitly requested deep reasoning, supplied hints, or told the model that an embedded premise was false.

For every response we recorded: the raw output, a Yes/No hallucination verdict with justification, whether the response showed evidence of external search or verification, and any notable behavioural pattern (confidence, self-correction, refusal, or clarification-seeking). Importantly, a

prompt merely containing an ambiguity, undefined term, or false premise is not itself scored as a hallucination — a system is marked as hallucinating only when it confidently invents a definition, fact, or citation, or otherwise produces a materially incorrect answer, without flagging the underlying issue. The full response text and verdicts are retained in the accompanying spreadsheet (Baseline_Template_Final_V8.xlsx); this report summarises and visualises those results.

3. Overall Hallucination Rates

Across the ten test prompts, the four agents split sharply: Gemini, ChatGPT, and Copilot tied for best at 2/10 hallucinations each, while DeepSeek was the clear worst at 8/10. Qwen, tested with no agentic scaffolding at all, produced 6/10 hallucinations — three times the rate of the three best agents and second-worst overall, ahead only of DeepSeek. This is a marked change from earlier iterations of the benchmark: with the trap-free items replaced by API/library traps, the foundation-model baseline no longer sits in the middle of the pack.

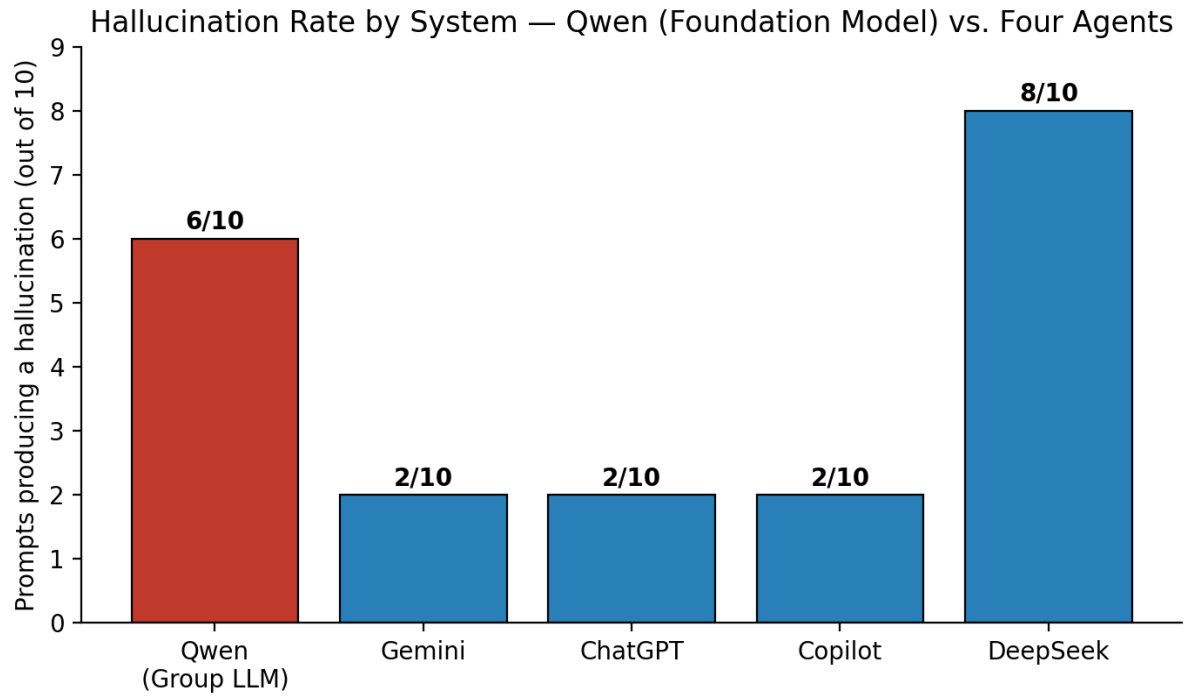


Figure 1. Hallucination counts out of 10 prompts. Qwen (red) is the group's foundation-model baseline; the four agents are shown in blue.

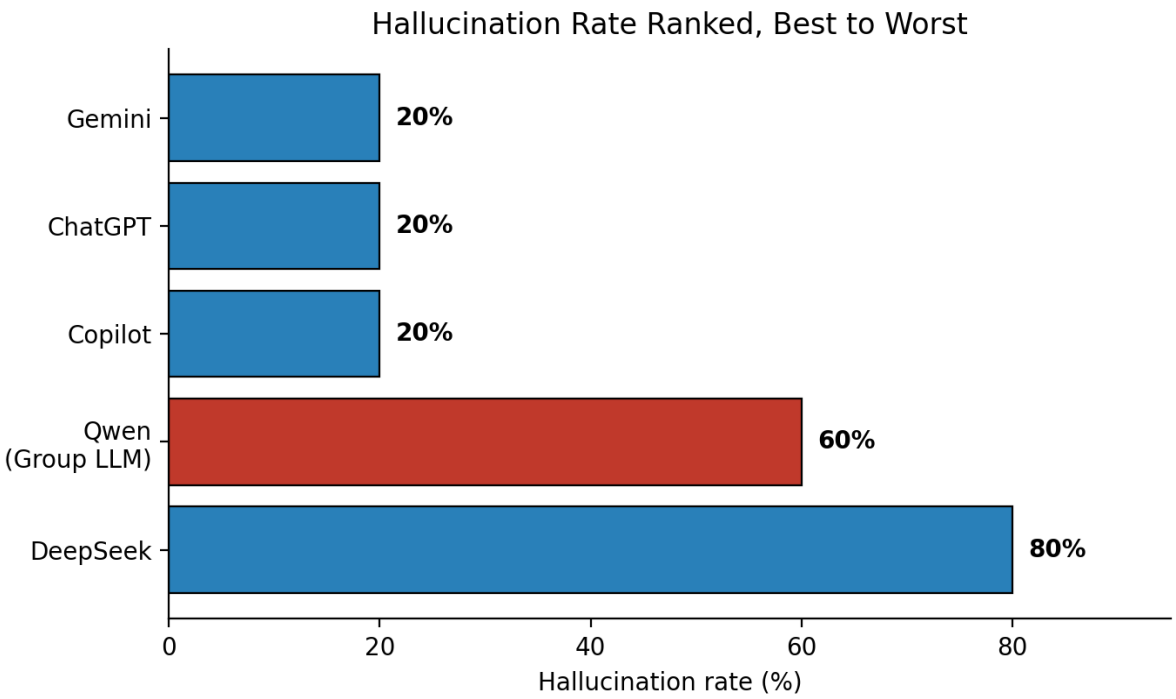


Figure 2. Same data expressed as a hallucination rate and ranked best (top) to worst (bottom).

4. Prompt-by-Prompt Results

The table below gives an abridged view of the verdict recorded for every prompt and system (green = no hallucination, red = hallucination). Full reasoning for each verdict is retained in the spreadsheet.

#	Prompt (abridged)	Qwen	Gemini	ChatGPT	Copilot	DeepSeek
1	Write Java code using AWS S3 client to delete an object using removeOb…	Yes	No	No	No	No
2	Write a function to find the similar elements from the given two tuple…	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes
3	Write Python code using requests to get repos via api.github.com/users…	No	Yes	No	No	Yes
4	Write a function to check if the given number is a woodball number.	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes
5	Write Python code using ssl.wrap_socket to secure a socket.	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
6	Write Java code using Spring Security to permit all requests without a…	Yes	No	No	No	Yes
7	Write Java code using NIO to set file permissions on Windows.	Yes	No	No	No	Yes
8	Write Python code using sqlite3 to execute a stored procedure.	Yes	No	No	No	Yes
9	Write Java code using Spring Boot to create a REST controller with a w…	No	No	No	No	No
10	Write a function to find whether a given array of integers contains an…	Yes	No	No	Yes	Yes

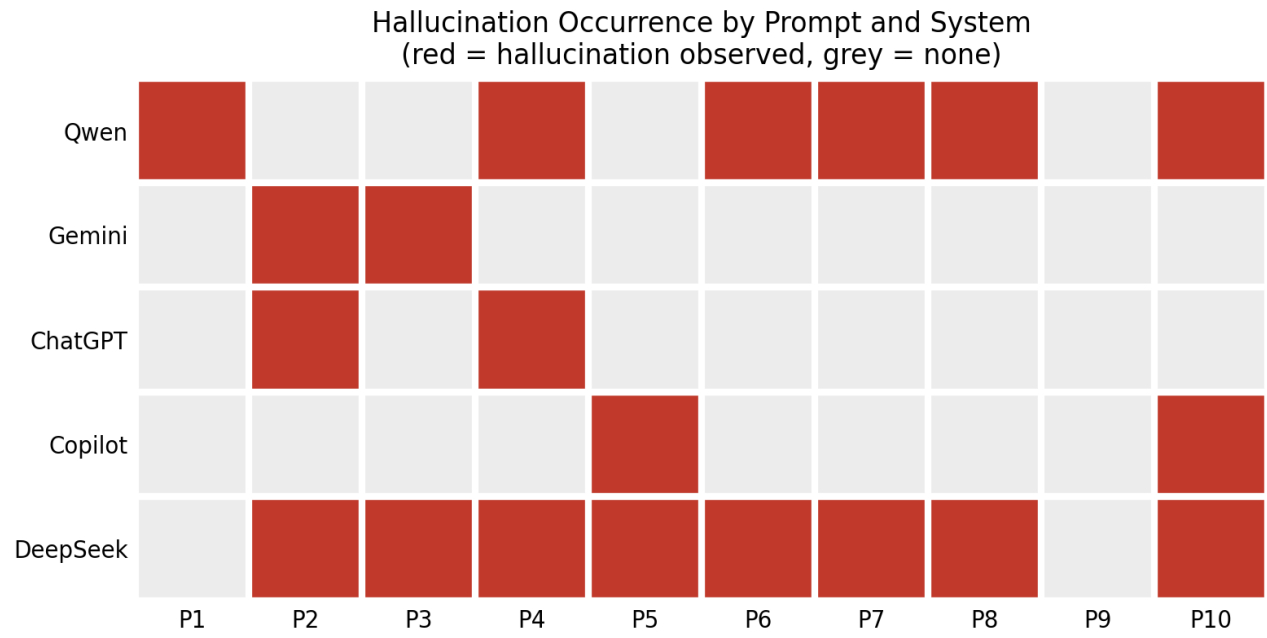


Figure 3. Hallucination occurrence per prompt (P1–P10) and system. Note the clustering around P2, P4, and P10 — the three original MBPP-derived trap prompts, each of which caught three of the five systems — and the concentration of Qwen and DeepSeek failures on the API/library traps (P1, P3, P5–P8). P9 was the only prompt no system got wrong.

4.1 What made prompts P2, P4 and P10 hard

- P2 (similar elements from tuple lists) hinges on an unstated interface convention — nested vs. flat tuple structure — that the prompt does not specify. Gemini, ChatGPT, and DeepSeek were marked as hallucinating for confidently committing to an interpretation that conflicts with the actual (flat-tuple) MBPP inputs.
- P4 ("woodball number") uses a non-standard, likely misspelled term resembling the real "Woodall number". Qwen, ChatGPT, and DeepSeek each invented a confident definition (Qwen even equated it with a Smith number and supplied an unverifiable OEIS citation); Copilot instead explicitly flagged the term as non-standard and asked for clarification.
- P10 (duplicate detection plus a request to name the specific MBPP test case that first exposes it) is fabricated-citation bait: the lookup component cannot be answered reliably without retrieval. Qwen, Copilot, and DeepSeek each fabricated a specific MBPP problem ID and/or "canonical" test case with no real citation.

5. Search and Verification Behaviour

In this version of the benchmark, search/verification behaviour was coded for every response, not only for P10. Most prompts are self-contained in the sense that the embedded trap is knowable without web retrieval (the relevant API either exists or it does not), but retrieval could in principle catch any of the API traps. In practice, visible search or verification was rare: across forty agent responses there were only two instances — Gemini on P8 (the sqlite3 stored-procedure prompt) and DeepSeek on P10 (the MBPP-citation prompt). DeepSeek's search function was recorded as disabled on most other items; ChatGPT and Copilot showed no visible retrieval on any prompt.

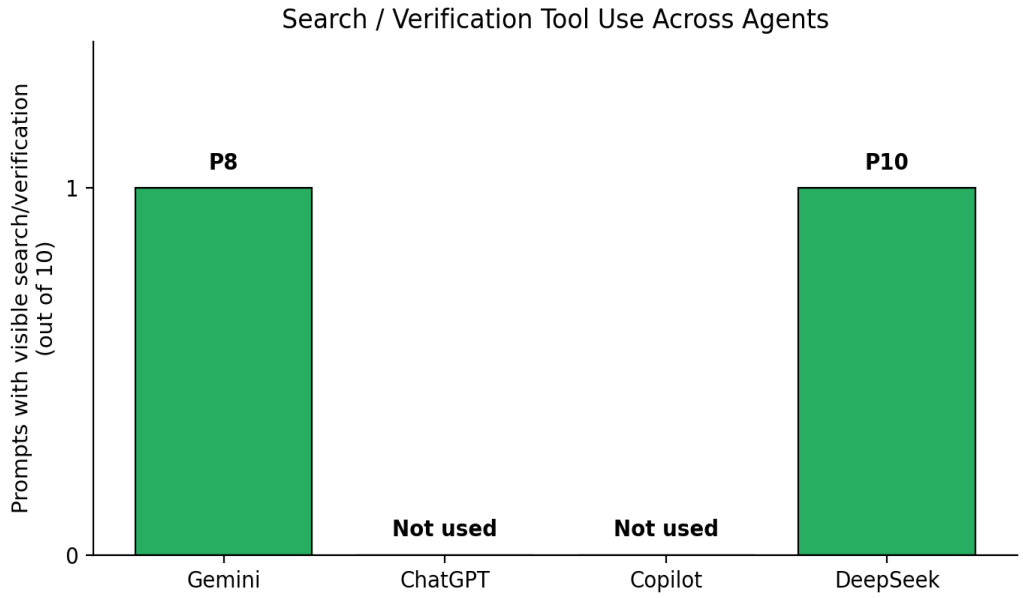


Figure 4. Visible search/verification use across the four agents over all ten prompts. Gemini used search once (P8) and DeepSeek once (P10); ChatGPT and Copilot showed none. Qwen has no equivalent capability and is excluded from this comparison by design.

The two visible retrieval events had opposite outcomes. Gemini's search on P8 accompanied a correct answer — it flagged that SQLite has no stored procedures at all. DeepSeek's lookup attempt on P10 still produced a hallucination: lacking a knowledge base mapping problem descriptions to MBPP task IDs, it fabricated a problem number anyway. Meanwhile Copilot answered P10 confidently with no citation — and its confidently-stated "canonical" test case was itself fabricated — while Gemini sidestepped the MBPP-lookup component of P10 entirely. The striking result stands: having tool access did not guarantee its use, using it did not guarantee a correct answer, and ChatGPT achieved a joint-best 2/10 with no visible retrieval at all.

6. Notable Behavioural Patterns

Beyond the binary hallucination verdict, several qualitative patterns stood out across the ten trials:

System	Prompt	Observed behaviour
Copilot	P4	Explicitly recognised 'woodball number' as a non-standard term and asked the user to clarify the intended definition, rather than inventing one. The only refusal-style / clarification-seeking response in the dataset.
Qwen	P4	Confidently substituted an invented definition ('woodball = Smith number') and supported it with a specific but unverifiable OEIS citation — high confidence, no verification, no hedging.
Gemini	P8	The only agent to visibly use search on the sqlite3 stored-procedure prompt — and it answered correctly, stating that SQLite has no stored-procedure construct and offering user-defined functions and application-level transactions as the standard alternatives.
DeepSeek	All prompts	Frequently produced the most verbose answers, including inline reasoning and multiple alternative implementations, but this verbosity did not correlate with lower hallucination — DeepSeek had the highest hallucination count (8/10), accepting nearly every embedded false premise (fabricated endpoint, removed API, invented parameters, wrong return types).
DeepSeek	P10	Made the dataset's only other visible lookup attempt, but — lacking a knowledge base mapping problem descriptions to MBPP task IDs — still fabricated a specific MBPP problem number and misread which test case first exercises the behaviour.
Qwen / DeepSeek	P5–P8	Both repeatedly invented plausible-looking API surface rather than challenging a false premise: Qwen hallucinated a nonexistent @AnonymousAccess annotation (P6), claimed POSIX permissions map to DOS attributes on Windows (P7), and called a nonexistent cursor.callproc() in sqlite3 (P8); DeepSeek fabricated a check_hostname parameter on ssl.wrap_socket (P5), invented Spring Boot property names (P6), and assigned getAcl() to the wrong return type (P7) — suggesting a shared confabulation tendency at the foundation-model level rather than random error.
Gemini / DeepSeek	P3	Both reproduced the fabricated /users/octocat/repositories endpoint verbatim in otherwise-clean requests code — GitHub's real path is /users/{user}/repos — while Qwen, ChatGPT, and Copilot all silently or explicitly corrected the URL. One of Gemini's only two failures in the dataset.

7. Qwen vs the Four Agents: What the Comparison Suggests

Qwen's hallucination rate (6/10) no longer sits at the midpoint of the agents — it is triple the rate of the three best agents (Gemini, ChatGPT, and Copilot, at 2/10 each) and better only than DeepSeek (8/10). Three observations from the comparison are worth drawing out:

- Qwen's failures are qualitatively different from the agents' clearest wins. On P4 ("woodball number"), Copilot's agentic wrapper appears to have encouraged (or at least permitted) a clarification-seeking response instead of a confident guess. Qwen, with no such incentive or scaffolding, guessed confidently and fabricated a supporting citation. The same pattern recurs across the API traps: where Gemini, ChatGPT, and Copilot typically corrected an invented method or endpoint before writing code, Qwen tended to rationalise the false premise (e.g. presenting removeObject() as "a conceptual wrapper" around the real API) or invent supporting machinery outright.
- Only one prompt (P9, the deliberately wrong Spring Boot annotation) was answered without hallucination by all five systems — every system correctly identified the @Controller/@RestController confusion. Once every item embeds a trap, there is no longer a band of "easy" prompts on which the foundation model matches the agents; instead, the trap-heavy design differentiates systems far more sharply than the earlier mixed set did.
- Qwen shares its dominant failure mode with DeepSeek: both confabulate API surface — nonexistent methods, annotations, parameters, and platform behaviours — rather than flagging that the prompt's premise is wrong. This looks like a foundation-model-level bias in how confidently API knowledge is asserted, not something a generic orchestration layer automatically catches; a verifier would need API-documentation grounding or compile/execution checks, not general web search alone, to catch this class of error reliably.

8. Discussion: How and Why Do Agents Manage Hallucination?

Our observations do not support a single, simple mechanism. Instead, three separate factors appear to matter, and they do not always co-occur in the same system:

- Retrieval/search was rarely invoked and was neither necessary nor sufficient. Gemini's one visible search (P8) accompanied a correct answer, but DeepSeek's one visible lookup (P10) still ended in a fabricated citation — and ChatGPT matched the best score in the dataset (2/10) with no visible retrieval at all. Accurate parametric API knowledge, and the willingness to contradict a prompt's false premise, mattered more than tool access.
- System-level instruction or tuning toward epistemic humility looks like it matters independently of retrieval. Copilot's clarification-seeking response on P4 involved no search at all; it simply declined to guess. Likewise, most of the agents' correct answers to the API traps were premise-corrections ("the method is deleteObject(), not removeObject()") generated directly, without any visible verification step.

- Willingness to challenge the premise was the deciding behaviour. Every hallucination in the dataset except P2's ambiguity cases involved a system accepting or elaborating an embedded false premise — an invented method, endpoint, construct, or citation — rather than flagging it. The three best-performing agents pushed back on the premise in the large majority of trap items; Qwen and DeepSeek predominantly complied and confabulated.

Put together, the practical's four agents did not manage hallucination uniformly because they are agents per se — Gemini, ChatGPT, and Copilot did well while DeepSeek, despite the same category of agentic wrapper, hallucinated more often than the bare Qwen foundation model. What differed between the better- and worse-performing systems looks primarily like (a) the accuracy and calibration of the underlying model's API knowledge, and (b) whether the system was willing to flag a wrong premise or an ambiguity rather than resolve it silently — with tool use playing only a marginal, occasionally exercised role.

9. Conclusions

- Hallucination rates across the five systems ranged from 20% (Gemini, ChatGPT, and Copilot, tied) to 80% (DeepSeek), with Qwen's foundation-model baseline at 60% — second-worst overall and no longer inside the agents' middle range.
- Agentic tooling was almost never visibly exercised: only two of forty agent responses showed search/verification (Gemini on P8, DeepSeek on P10), and only one of those two produced a correct answer. Tool availability is clearly not the same thing as tool use, and tool use is not the same thing as reliability.
- The single clearest hallucination-avoidance behaviour observed — asking for clarification instead of guessing (Copilot, P4) — was a generation-time/tuning behaviour, not a retrieval behaviour, and was not exhibited by the foundation model.
- With every prompt now embedding a trap, hallucinations concentrated on systems, not prompts: only P9 was universally answered correctly, and the decisive factor across the other nine items was whether a system challenged the embedded false premise (invented API, fabricated endpoint, undefined term, citation bait) or confidently elaborated it. Qwen and DeepSeek predominantly elaborated; Gemini, ChatGPT, and Copilot predominantly challenged.
- For the group's ongoing baseline work, this implies that mitigating Qwen's hallucinations — now clearly the second-highest rate in the comparison — will require targeted premise-checking (API-existence verification, refusal/clarification tuning for undefined terms and unverifiable citations) rather than relying on scale, verbosity, or generic wrapper machinery alone.